Having failed to capture a Chinese soldier, Hoshiar decided to send out a three-company-strong raiding party that would give the Chinese a hard knock. The composite force made up of two companies of 2 Sikh LI and Alpha Company of 1 Sikh plus one platoon under the command of Major S. S. Jaspal, the 2IC of 2 Sikh LI set off for Lunguthang on 15 November to engage any Chinese troops to be found there. The fighting reconnaissance party had enough supplies to sustain themselves for four days. The guns were on standby and a FOO was allotted to the party. Irani, the commanding officer of 2 Sikh LI, moved his command post to Kye-la to watch the progress of the column, code-named Kaua (Crow), which left the battalion HQ at 4.30 a.m.

This plan was flawed right from the very outset. Hoshiar Singh should have known that the Chinese were highly unlikely to present a static target especially south of the Tawang/Mago Chu, where they themselves were infiltrating on the flanks, hoping to draw the Indians out of their prepared defences. Also, somebody in the chain of command should have realized that combining troops from the Sikh and Sikh LI units was a recipe for disaster. Despite Sikhism's tenets forbidding casteism, the reality on the ground was quite different, especially during the mid-twentieth century. The two Sikh LI units were Mazhabi or low-caste Sikhs. In their villages, they lived in a state of virtual apartheid, dominated by middle-caste Jat Sikhs who made up the Sikh Regiment. Both these regiments of the Indian Army have time and again proven themselves to be outstanding soldiers, but to mix them up was always going to be fraught with danger. In the event, Hoshiar Singh literally blundered into the Chinese trap and the ill-fated and ill-conceived attempt would have the worst possible outcome.

The composite patrol, after crossing the Lunguthang–Kye-la ridgeline, proceeded towards the northeast. Jaspal wanted to get to the highest point in the area, beyond which flowed the Goro Chu. By the evening, the exhausted column reached Dzalung-la, where the Sikh company started establishing a firm base just below the pass, while the two Sikh LI companies continued to probe the area towards Lunguthang, close to which they established a night harbour. The Chinese on their part had been stung by the Goswami incident the previous night and were quite alert. They had been shadowing the Indian composite force from the time they set out while themselves remaining undetected. It was obvious from the way they used the topography of the area that they were familiar with its features. At 2 a.m.,